

Cross-Curricular Inquiry Project: Lesson Plan

General Information

Title	The Journey of Salmon: Connecting People, Land, Water, and Community
Grade Level	Grade 1–2
Duration	2 Weeks
Big Inquiry Question	How are salmon connected to people, land, water, and community?

Rationale

This inquiry project invites primary students to explore the vital importance of salmon within Indigenous cultures and local ecosystems in British Columbia. Rather than treating science and social studies as isolated subjects, this unit intentionally weaves them together through traditional storytelling, hands-on observation, artistic expression, and deep personal reflection.

Following an inquiry-based learning framework and integrating First Peoples perspectives in an authentic, meaningful way, students move beyond simple memorization. They develop a foundational understanding of interconnectedness, relationality, and respect for the natural world, learning that our actions directly impact the environment around us.

BC Curriculum Connections

Grounded in the British Columbia Ministry of Education Curriculum frameworks.

1. Science

- **Big Idea:** Living things have features and behaviours that help them survive in their environment. (*Focusing on the specific adaptations and habitat needs of local salmon populations*).
- **Curricular Competencies:**
 - Observe objects and events in familiar contexts.

- Ask questions about familiar objects and events based on personal curiosity.
- Make simple predictions based on prior experiences and background knowledge.

2. Social Studies

- **Big Idea:** Indigenous knowledge and traditions within the local community.
 - Relationships between people and the environment over time.
- **Curricular Competencies:**
 - Recognize the significance of place by learning who has cared for this land since time immemorial.
 - Explore different perspectives and experiences through local narratives and oral histories.

3. English Language Arts

- **Big Idea:** Stories and other texts help us learn about ourselves, our families, and our communities.
- **Curricular Competencies:**
 - Exchange ideas, feelings, and perspectives through active listening and respectful speaking.
 - Create personal stories, detailed drawings, and oral responses to reflect on learning experiences.

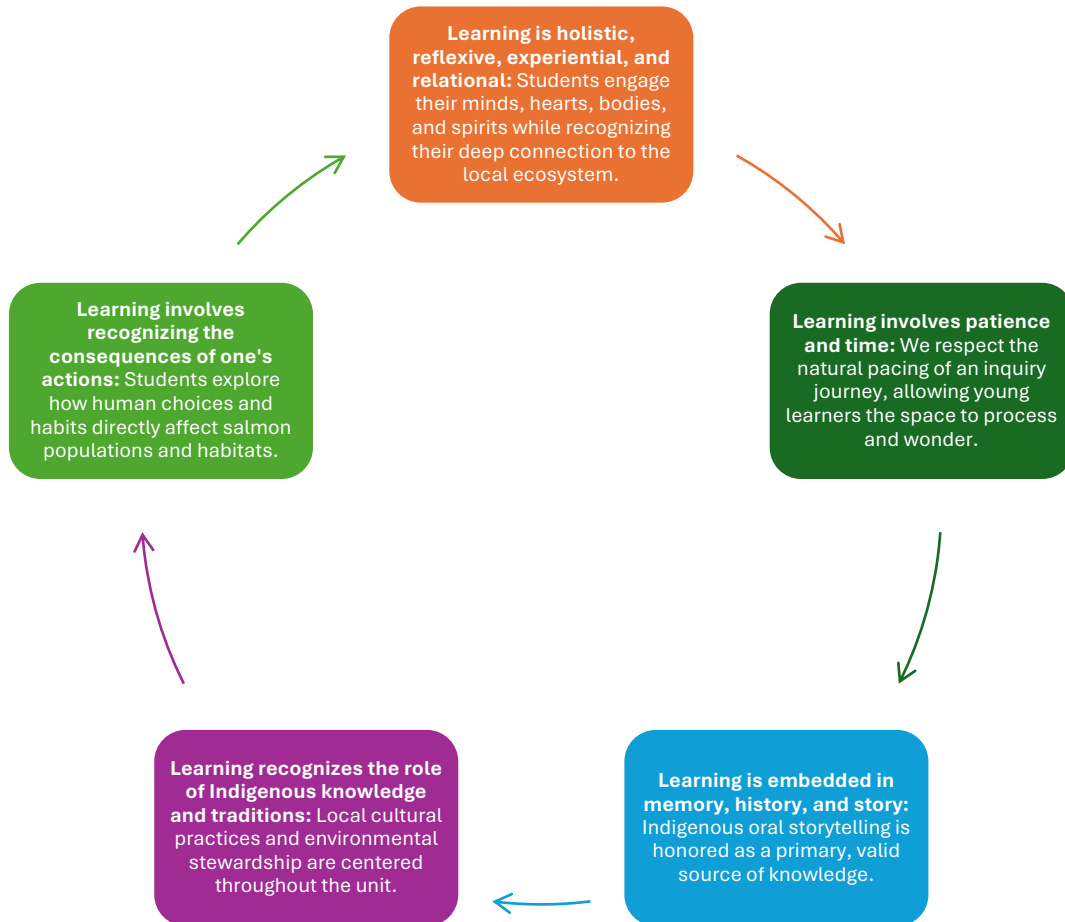
4. Arts Education

- **Big Idea:** People connect to others and share ideas through the arts.
- **Curricular Competencies:**
 - Express personal ideas, emotions, and cultural understandings through creative works.

- Create artistic representations based on outdoor observations and lived experiences.

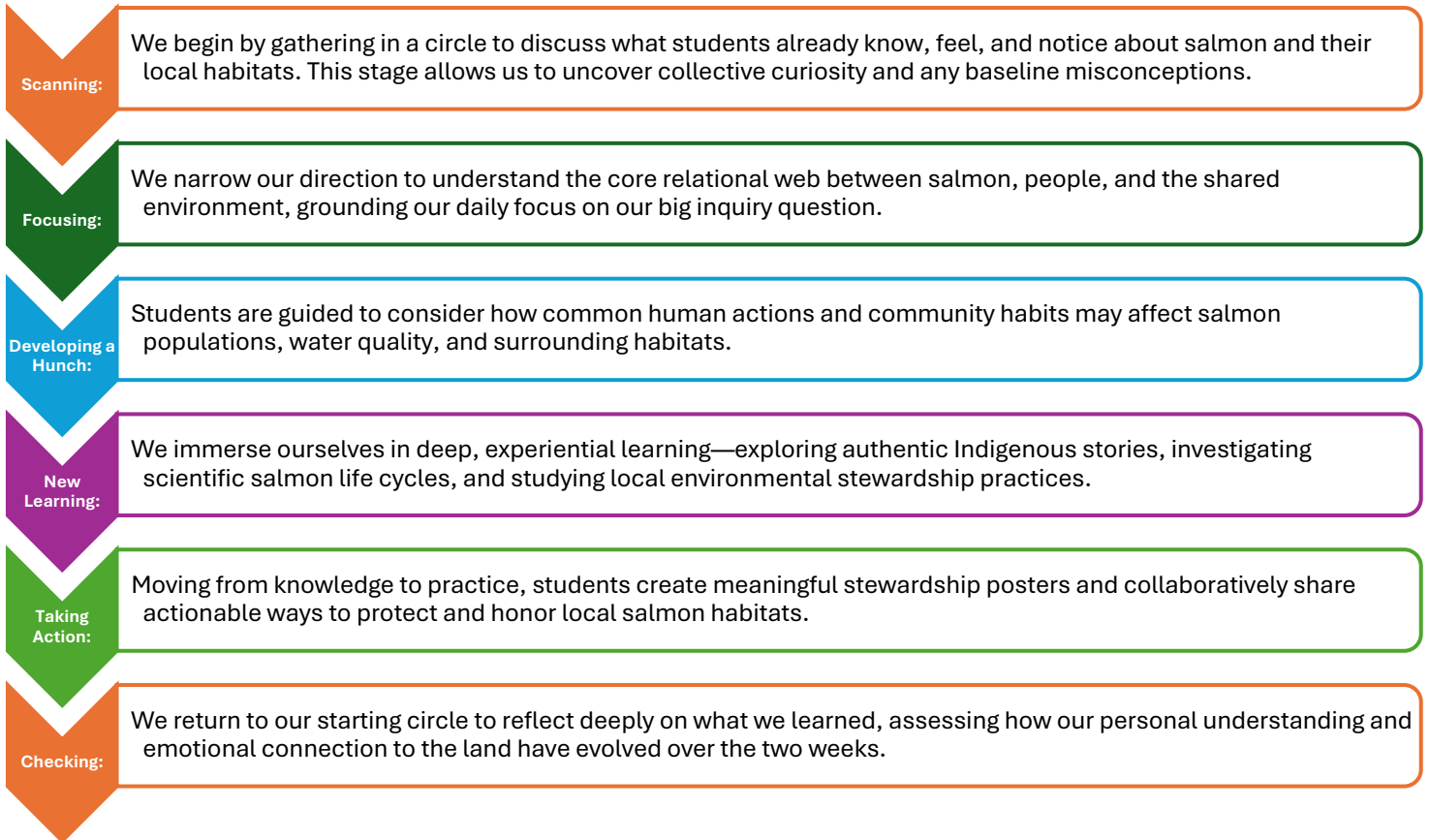
First Peoples Principles of Learning (FPPL)

This project is intentionally designed to reflect an authentic understanding that:



Spiral of Inquiry Framework (NOIIE)

Aligned with the methodology outlined by the Network of Inquiry and Indigenous Education, the unit flows through six interconnected stages:



Four Directions Learning Framework

This holistic framework ensures that we actively engage the whole child—spirit, heart, mind, and body—throughout the inquiry.

1. Spirit – Awareness & Connection

- **Focus:** Cultivating a spiritual, respectful connection to the natural world and honoring oral traditions.

- **Guiding Questions:** Why are salmon important? What can we learn from traditional stories? How are people connected to nature?
- **Learning Activity:** We will gather in a respectful space to read an authentic, regionally appropriate Indigenous story about salmon. Following the reading, students will participate in a structured talking circle where they share their thoughts and reflect on how living things depend on one another.

2. Heart – Emotional Relationality

- **Focus:** Exploring personal feelings of responsibility, gratitude, and empathy for nature.
- **Learning Activity:** Students will share personal experiences they have had near local rivers, lakes, or streams, discussing how it feels to be in a healthy ecosystem. We will discuss tangible ways to care for these waters, leading into a personal reflection journal prompt:

"I can show respect for nature by..."

3. Mind – Intellectual Knowledge

- **Focus:** Investigating the biological salmon life cycle and analyzing how salmon contribute to the wider ecosystem.
- **Inquiry Questions:** What do salmon need to survive? What happens during each stage of the life cycle?
- **Learning Activities:** Watch a short, localized educational video about salmon and their environmental needs. *"The Pacific Salmon Life Cycle"* by Fisheries and Oceans Canada to observe how salmon develop from eggs to adults.

- Create a hands-on "Salmon Life Cycle Wheel" where students illustrate, color, and label each critical stage:

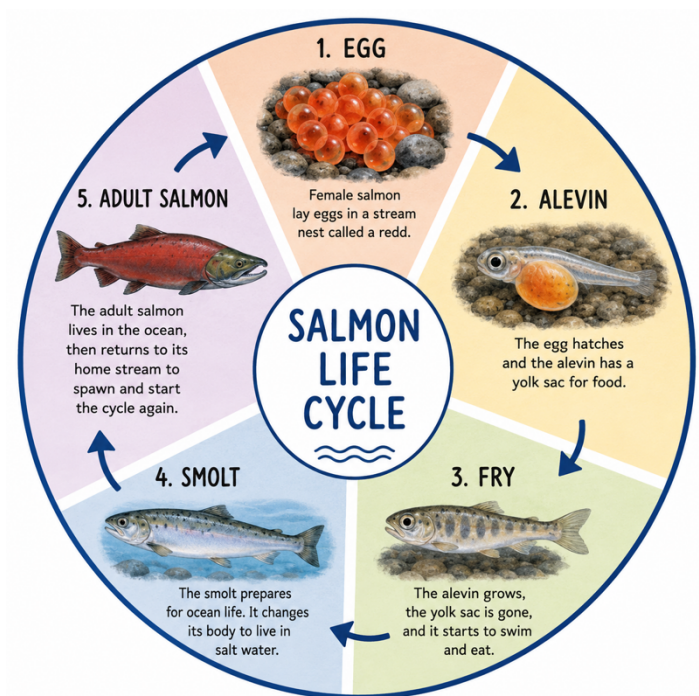


Figure 1

Salmon Life Cycle Wheel. Adapted from information provided by Fisheries and Oceans Canada (n.d.).

4. Body – Physical & Experiential Action

- **Focus:** Participating in active, kinesthetic, and place-based learning experiences.
- **Learning Activities:**
 - * **Outdoor Observation Walk:** A sensory walk to a local stream or wooded space near the school to observe water flows, gravel quality, and plant life.
 - **Nature Journaling:** Students record their immediate physical observations through detailed drawings and simple written descriptions.
 - **Creative Expression:** Creating a vibrant salmon art project using paint, collage, or mixed media to represent their animal connection.
 - **Stewardship Posters:** Designing advocacy posters to share real ways to keep our watersheds clean.

Purposeful Technology Integration

Technology is used intentionally to support, document, and amplify student inquiry without distracting from place-based learning:

- **Visual Access:** Watching educational videos about salmon habitats to see underwater environments up close.
- **Field Documentation:** Using tablets or classroom devices during our outdoor walk to photograph personal observations, which students can reference later for their artwork.
- **Creative Synthesis:** Giving students the choice to create digital drawings or simple presentations to showcase their findings.
- **Inclusive Reflection:** Recording oral reflections about their learning on classroom devices, ensuring students who are still developing written literacy can fully express their critical thinking.

Student Handout

The Journey of Salmon

Our Inquiry Question: How are salmon connected to people, land, water, and community?

Name: _____

My Project Checklist

Over the next two weeks, we are going to explore the beautiful world around us like scientists, artists, and storytellers! Check off each box as you complete the activities:

- ☐ **Listen** closely to beautiful Indigenous stories about the Salmon People.
- ☐ **Ask** big and curious questions about nature and our local environment.
- ☐ **Explore** nature outside using my senses during our stream observation walk.
- ☐ **Learn** all the scientific stages of how salmon grow and change.
- ☐ **Create** my own interactive salmon life cycle wheel.
- ☐ **Design** vibrant artwork and a stewardship poster to protect our environment.
- ☐ **Work** kindly and helpfully with my classmates and teachers.

Success Criteria (What I can do!)

By the end of this project, I will be able to proudly say:

- ☐ **I can investigate!** I can ask thoughtful questions about salmon and their homes.
- ☐ **I can be a scientist!** I can explain and sequence the stages of the salmon life cycle (*Egg, Alevin, Fry, Smolt, and Adult Salmon*).
- ☐ **I can be reflective!** I can describe why salmon are so important to British Columbia's ecosystems and communities.
- ☐ **I can listen and share!** I can share an important teaching or lesson I learned from Indigenous stories.
- ☐ **I can be a caretaker (Steward)!** I can identify real ways to care for and protect local salmon habitats.

Assessment Tool: Teacher Observation Rubric

This formative assessment tool tracks student growth based on BC Curricular Competencies and holistic participation.

Criteria	Emerging	Developing	Proficient
Participation in Discussions	Participates in talking circles and class discussions only when provided with direct teacher support or sentence frames.	Participates regularly, listens respectfully to peers, and shares ideas during community circles.	Participates independently, shares deep insights, and actively builds upon the ideas of others.
Understanding of Salmon Life Cycle	Identifies some random stages of the life cycle but struggles to sequence them accurately.	Identifies most stages of the life cycle and places them in the correct chronological order.	Explains all stages clearly, detailing what salmon need to survive during each phase of their journey.
Understanding of Indigenous Perspectives	Demonstrates a beginning awareness that stories carry traditional teachings, but	Demonstrates some understanding of the lessons and morals embedded within the shared	Demonstrates a respectful and deep understanding of traditional knowledge,

	needs help connecting them to nature.	Indigenous narratives.	connection to place, and relationality.
Stewardship and Environmental Responsibility	Identifies one basic action to help the environment when prompted directly.	Identifies several practical actions to care for local watersheds and salmon environments.	Confidently explains practical stewardship actions and articulates their long-term importance to the community.
Communication of Learning	Shares limited information about their learning, relying heavily on heavily assisted drawings or single words.	Shares key ideas and accurate concepts through a mix of art, digital drawings, and written responses.	Clearly and creatively communicates a deep understanding of inquiry findings using multiple expressive modes.

Teacher Reflection

To be completed post-implementation to gauge inquiry depth and pedagogical growth:

Questions for Reflection:

1. Were students actively engaged and self-driven throughout the inquiry process?
2. Did students make explicit, authentic connections between salmon, people, and the local environment?
3. How effectively and respectfully were Indigenous perspectives integrated into our daily learning experiences?
4. What concrete evidence (journals, recordings, artwork) showed true growth in student understanding?
5. What specific structural or pacing changes could improve future implementation of this project?

REFERENCES:

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